



CROSS EXAMINATION
(From extreme left) Stills from *Guilty Minds*, *Criminal Justice* and *Your Honor*

tension. OTT is a "powerful medium", she says, for one can "cover so much legal ground" and also "have satisfying arcs for so many characters".

Apurva Asrani concurs. The writer of two acclaimed legal procedural films, *Shahid* (2012) and *Aligarh* (2015), he feels viewers enjoy "the luxury of privacy" that OTT content affords them. This enables creators like him to "explore more risqué themes and narratives". Asrani says, "I know a lot of men who were embarrassed to be seen in a theatre [watching] *Aligarh*, lest they be labelled 'gay'." For season two of *Criminal Justice*, he focused on marital rape through the case of a wife accused of killing her high-profile lawyer husband.

Asrani takes pride in the fact that his work has struck a chord. Not only was *Aligarh* cited by the Supreme Court judgment decriminalising homosexuality, *Criminal Justice* was also referred to by some on social media as a critique of Justice C. Hari Shankar's verdict in the criminalisation of marital rape case. Unlike Shefali, though, Asrani isn't too concerned about legal parlance: "I try to avoid getting too technical. It is my belief that the Indian audience is more emotional than cerebral, therefore the characters, their challenges, their motivations take precedence over pitch perfect constructions of cases." Either way, we now know our audiences are as taken by lawyers as they are by lawbreakers. ■

–Suhani Singh

WATCHLIST

Ball in Their Court



THE LINCOLN LAWYER (2022-)
Netflix
Based on Michael Connelly's bestselling novels, the series tells the story of Mickey Haller (Manuel Garcia-Rulfo), an iconoclastic LA criminal defence attorney whose office is, oddly, his SUV (a Lincoln Town Car in the original novels)



PERRY MASON (2020-)
Disney+ Hotstar
Adapted from the fiction of Erle Stanley Gardner and set in booming 1932 LA, the show follows Perry Mason (Matthew Rhys), a down-and-out attorney who is suddenly handed the case of a lifetime



BETTER CALL SAUL (2015-)
Netflix
The show is a prequel to *Breaking Bad* (2008-13), yes, but is also so much more. It is riveting to see ex-con Jimmy McGill (Bob Odenkirk) transform into morally challenged lawyer Saul Goodman